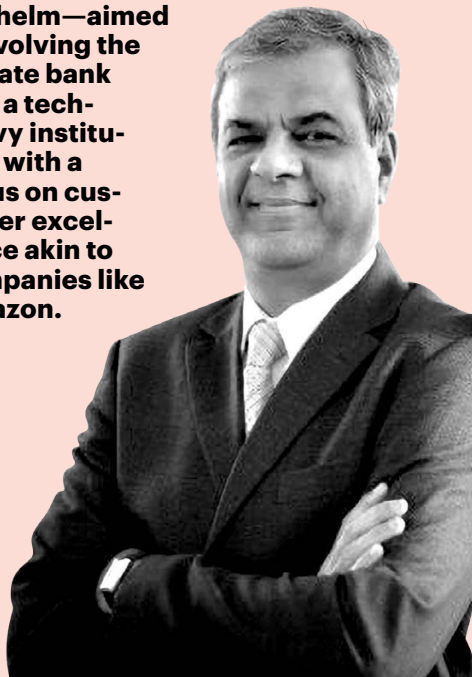


READY FOR THE TEST

Springing a surprise in November 2023, Kotak Mahindra Bank announced the appointment of **Ashok Vaswani** as its new MD & CEO. With Founder and Director Uday Kotak expected to keep a close watch from within the bank's board, Vaswani has his task cut out. The challenge for him lies in building a rapport with the senior management while driving the transformative strategy—initiated when Kotak was at the helm—aimed at evolving the private bank into a tech-savvy institution with a focus on customer excellence akin to companies like Amazon.



Poor Visibility Ahead

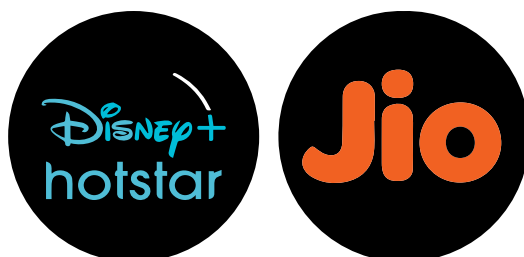
The pandemic is behind us (notwithstanding new outbreaks of Covid-19), but its impact is still being felt on the India's consumer sector. The inability of those at the bottom of the pyramid to spend is expected to keep manufacturers and marketers on their toes in H1CY24. From manufacturers of entry-level cars and scooters to makers of daily essentials, everyone is rueing the subdued consumer sentiment as volume offtake in the rural market continues to remain in the negative zone. But with the rural economy recovering slowly, there's hope for H2CY24.



THE NEXT ACT

AS THE CURTAIN falls on 2023, Bollywood would be hoping that the good run continues in the New Year. Thanks to blockbusters like *Gadar 2*, *Pathaan*, *Jawan*, and *Animal* Bollywood's total worldwide collections hit ₹12,729.66 crore in 2023, per Sacnilk, that tracks box office numbers. Insiders are hoping that 2024, too, will see a similar number, riding on much-anticipated movies such as Vasan Bala's *Jigra*, starring Alia Bhatt; *Fighter*, featuring Deepika Padukone and Hrithik Roshan; and *Kalki 2898 AD*, that has Padukone and Prabhas in lead roles. The stage is all set for Bollywood's next act. Will the audiences oblige?

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GAME CHANGER?

BILLIONAIRE MUKESH AMBANI'S Reliance Industries is on the cusp of another game-changing move as it looks to acquire Disney's India business. Although not confirmed yet, the deal is expected to create a powerhouse—with more than 100 channels, two streaming platforms and rights to three major cricket properties across TV and digital platforms. Given these implications, it is likely to pose fierce competition for global OTT giants, spur consolidation among smaller players, and put pressure on rival telecom player Bharti Airtel to intensify its content partnerships.